Democracy

One line: How democracy evolved in India — from ancient collective decision-making traditions to the world's largest constitutional democracy — its principles, forms, practices and challenges.

⚡ 5-Minute Revision | 💡 Hinglish | 📜 Articles & Dates | 🔥 Must-Remember Facts | 📝 Answer Guide

1 Chapter at a Glance

- **Democracy** = government in which the source of power & authority lies with the **citizens**, who elect representatives through **free & fair elections**; founded on freedom, equality, justice, rights & duties
- **Big questions:** How has the idea of democracy evolved? What are its forms in India & the world? What are its essential features beyond institutions? What challenges does Indian democracy face?
- **India = world's largest democracy 🔥:** population 140+ crore, voters 96.8 crore (2024)
- **Constitution 🔥:** adopted **26 November 1949**, in force **26 January 1950**; guarantees Fundamental Rights; no discrimination on religion, race, caste, sex, place of birth

2 Key Terms — one-line meanings

Popular sovereignty — ultimate source of power = the people

Rule of Law — no one above the law; disputes by legal procedures, not force

Equal protection of law — all in similar circumstances treated equally

Separation of Powers — legislature makes, executive implements, judiciary interprets

PIL — Public Interest Litigation; court action for public interest

Federalism — power shared centre ↔ states (Union, State, Concurrent lists)

Question Hour — first hour of a session; members question the government

Cooperatives — groups for common benefit; shared profits & responsibilities

Emergency — Articles 352 (National), 356 (President's Rule), 360 (Financial)

Universal Adult Franchise — every citizen 18+ votes by secret ballot, no discrimination

Equality before law — every individual treated equally by law

Procedure established by law — no punishment without due process/statute

Judicial review — judiciary can declare a law unconstitutional

Civil society — voluntary groups, NGOs, community associations

Sovereignty — from Latin *superanus* ("supreme"); supreme final authority of a State

Quorum — minimum members needed for valid proceedings

Participatory democracy — engagement beyond elections (local councils, consultations)

Civic responsibility — respect others' rights, responsible social media, abide by laws

3 Democratic Traditions — India's Long Story 📌

VEDIC ROOTS	sabhā, samiti, vidhata — collective decision-making; early republics (gaṇas/saṁghas); king ruled in consultation with assemblies & ministers
BUDDHIST SAṀGHA	debate & discussion; members chose their leader & voted on decisions
VEDIC VERSE	Ṛig Veda 10.191.3 (Aikyamatya Sūktam): "Their counsel is one and the same; their assembly is one..." — consultation & consensus
COLONIAL SETBACK	invasions disrupted political fabric; by 19th century the British colonised most of the subcontinent, limiting people's participation
FREEDOM STRUGGLE	revived & strengthened democratic ideas among the people
CONSTITUTION	Constituent Assembly formed **1946**; **2 years 11 months 18 days** → world's longest written Constitution; **Dr. B.R. Ambedkar = Chairman of the Drafting Committee** 🔥; CAD wanted a dynamic document → **Article 368** (amendments) — "robust, flexible, transformative, responsive"; global democratic values also influenced the CAD

4 7 Principles of Democracy — non-negotiable 🔥 (whole section)

Principle	Meaning + key points	Example / why it matters
1 Popular sovereignty	Ultimate power = people; govt elected via free & fair elections	Universal Adult Franchise (18+, secret ballot) — no ruler without people's consent
2 Rule of law	No one above law; equality before + equal protection of law; court procedures, due process	Even a minister/PM can be tried — prevents misuse of power
3 Fundamental Rights	6 FRs safeguarding rights, freedom, dignity; enforceable; indivisible & inalienable; reasonable restrictions	Article 21A — Right to Education (added 2009): free & compulsory, ages 6–14
4 Separation of powers	Legislature–executive–judiciary; checks & balances; Parliament can amend but judiciary reviews	Judiciary = impartial guardian of the Constitution; PIL = access to justice
5 Accountability & transparency	Govts answerable via elections, public debates, civil society	**RTI Act 2005**; Question Hour; auditing of accounts
6 Multi-party system	Several parties contest; >50% seats = government, rest = opposition; function under **RP Act 1951**	India: 2,800+ registered parties — real choice
7 Safeguarding vulnerable groups	Protect all communities; resources distributed equitably	**Article 46**: special care for weaker sections, SCs & STs

- **The 6 FRs with articles 🔥:** Equality (14–18) • Freedom (19–22) • Against Exploitation (23–24) • Freedom of Religion (25–28) • Cultural & Educational (29–30) • Constitutional Remedies (32); remedies via **32 & 226** ⚠️ favourite exam list
- FRs (enforceable rights) ≠ Fundamental Duties (responsibilities) ≠ DPSP (guidelines for the State) ⚠️ classic confusion

5 Democratic Processes — institutions & values 📌

Process	Institutions	Democratic values
Legislative	Parliament, State legislatures, local bodies	Representation, deliberation, dissent
Electoral	Election Commission of India	Participation, equality
Judicial	Courts	Rule of law, equality, justice
Participatory	Civil society, media	Debate, freedom of expression
Accountability	CAG, CIC, Lokpal, CVC	Transparency
Decentralisation	Rural & urban local bodies	Grassroots participation
Checks & balances	Division of powers via written constitution	Devolution of power

- **Media = "fourth pillar of democracy"** 🔥 — informs people, raises public issues, voices of the masses
- Real strength of democracy = its **citizens** — participation, awareness of rights & duties, honesty

6 Types of Democracy 🔥 + world examples 📌

Type	Key features	Example
Direct	Citizens directly make most decisions; difficult in large countries	Switzerland
Representative (indirect)	Elect representatives; periodic elections; govt accountable	India
Parliamentary	Executive part of & accountable to legislature; people elect legislature, NOT executive	India, Canada, UK
Presidential	Executive independent of legislature; President elected by people	USA

- No single model — societies institutionalise democracy differently; but everywhere: freedom, equality, participation, rule of law, rights, duties
- Countries: **India** (President = Head of State + PM = Head of Govt; written constitution, federalism) • **Canada** (Governor-General + PM) • **UK** (constitutional monarchy, UNWRITTEN constitution) • **Switzerland** (Federal Council) • **USA** (President = both heads, two major parties) 📌

7 Democracy in Practice — India's Living Democracy

- Huge representation: **1 MP ≈ 25 lakh people** 📌; elections in **22 scheduled languages**; election symbols let non-literate citizens vote independently
- **Over 1 million polling stations** — mountains, forests, deserts, islands; sometimes a station for a **single voter**; **2,800+ parties** compete peacefully
- Three-tier system: Union → State → Local (Panchayati Raj & Municipalities)
- **Tribal protection ⭐:** Autonomous District Councils (ADCs) in the north-east (legislative + judicial powers to preserve tribal customs); **PESA Act 1996** — Gram Sabha = primary decision-making body in Scheduled Areas

🔥 CASE 1 — JETHIPURA GRAM PANCHAYAT (Gujarat)
Won **Nanaji Deshmukh Rashtriya Gaurav Gram Sabha Puraskar (NDRGGSP) 2019** — exemplary Gram Sabhas, records, Special Gram Sabhas, **Mahila Sabhas**, action on education/sanitation/welfare; quorum with active SC, ST & women participation.

🔥 CASE 2 — SOUTH MANUBANKUL (Tripura)
National-level **"women-friendly panchayat"** (Ministry of Panchayati Raj) — women in decision-making, health & livelihood facilities, self-help groups; democracy goes far beyond voting.

8 Women and Democracy 🔥

Country	Women got full voting rights
Britain	Only in **1928** — after decades of protest
USA	Only in **1920** — after long struggles
India	**From the very start — 1950**, Universal Adult Franchise to ALL, no legal battles needed 📌

- BUT right to vote ≠ equal participation — social prejudices still limit women's political representation
- **Article 243D 📌:** not less than ⅓ **seats for women** in every Panchayat; **21 States + 2 UTs raised it to 50%**
- **Article 243T 📌:** ⅓ for women in every Municipality; **17 States + 1 UT at 50%** (as of 2023); empowerment starts with participation in decision-making
- Grassroots leaders for rural poor & marginalised: **Chaudhary Charan Singh & Babu Jagjivan Ram** ⭐

9 The Right to Information (RTI) Act, 2005 🔥

- **How it became law** (democratic process in action): citizens, journalists, civil society & elected representatives raised concerns → parliamentary committees → expert groups → Parliament debate → consultations → safeguards for national security & efficiency → passed → in force **2005**
- **What it does:** empowers citizens to seek information from government departments → accountability & democratic governance; civil society + community institutions = bridges between citizens & the State (PIL, campaigns)

10 Challenges to Indian Democracy

- Democracy needs constant care, awareness & participation — from institutions AND citizens; rights must be exercised responsibly
- Everyday weakening: damaging public property, **misinformation/fake news (social media!)**, violating public rules, indifference
- Major challenges 📌: illiteracy, misinformation, inequality, poverty, regionalism, gender inequality, social discrimination, gaps in implementation (reduces trust)

BACKGROUND Early 1970s: dissatisfaction with Indira Gandhi's government — unemployment, inflation, misgovernance allegations → protests

WHAT HAPPENED	**June 1975: National Emergency** imposed on grounds of internal disturbance (Articles 352, 356, 360 = Emergency provisions)
EFFECTS	Majority of Fundamental Rights suspended; press censored; leaders & activists arrested; democratic institutions under severe strain
RESISTANCE	Mass movements by **Jayaprakash Narayan** (Lok Nayak) — mobilised students & citizens, esp. Bihar & Gujarat
RESULT & LESSON	Lifted **1977** → elections → government defeated by ballot. Showed vulnerability AND resilience of democracy + importance of constitutional safeguards & active citizens 🔥

11 Democracy and You — Young Citizens

- Being well-informed = vital responsibility — newspapers, news, responsible internet use
- Civic programmes ⭐: **NSS (National Service Scheme), NCC (National Cadet Corps), Bharat Scouts & Guides** — service, teamwork, democratic ideals
- Youth: know the Constitution, follow Fundamental Duties, be media literate, lead in school & community — democracy = continuous process, strength = informed responsible citizens 💡

12 💡 Hinglish Me Samjho — difficult concepts, ek line mein

Democracy ke Indian roots: Britishers se pehle hi — sabhā-samiti, Buddha ki Saṁgha mein voting, gaṇa-saṁgha republics. Freedom struggle ne values dobara jagayi.

FR vs Duties vs DPSP: FR = tumhare HAQ (court mein enforceable); Duties = tumhara FARZ; DPSP = SARKAR ke guidelines (welfare goals, enforceable nahi) — exam ka favourite confusion!

Parliamentary vs Presidential: India mein PM Parliament ke andar se (confidence vote pe answerable — tum MP ko vote dete ho, PM ko nahi); USA mein President seedha logon ke vote se.

PESA & ADC: ADC = north-east tribal areas ka apna chhota sarkar (customs bachao); PESA 1996 = Scheduled Areas mein Gram Sabha hi decision-maker. Dono ka goal: tribal heritage + self-governance.

RTI ka matlab: "right to question" — koi bhi citizen sarkari department se poochhe "kitna kharch hua?", sarkar ko jawaab dena padta hai. Corruption pakadne ka powerful hathiyar.

Emergency kya thi: 1975–77 rights suspend + press censorship + leaders jail; JP (Lok Nayak) ne andolan uthaya; 1977 mein janta ne ballot se jawab diya — democracy resilient hai!

13 🔥 MUST REMEMBER — if nothing else, this!

- **Constitution:** adopted **26 Nov 1949**, in force **26 Jan 1950**; CA **1946**; drafting = **2 yrs 11 months 18 days** (longest written); **Ambedkar** chaired Drafting Committee; amendments = **Article 368**
- **India's scale:** 140+ crore people, **96.8 crore voters** (2024), 1 MP ≈ 25 lakh, 22 languages, 1 million+ stations, 2,800+ parties
- **6 FRs:** 14–18, 19–22, 23–24, 25–28, 29–30, 32; remedies 32 & 226; **21A** = Right to Education (2009, ages 6–14)
- **Women's vote:** India **1950 (from the start)** / USA **1920** / Britain **1928**; **243D** Panchayat ⅓ (21+2 → 50%); **243T** Municipality ⅓ (17+1 → 50%)
- **Article 46** SC/ST welfare; **RTI 2005**; media = fourth pillar; accountability bodies: **CAG, CIC, Lokpal, CVC**
- **Types:** Direct (Switzerland) vs Representative (India); Parliamentary (India, Canada, UK) vs Presidential (USA)
- **Emergency 1975–77** (352, 356, 360): FRs suspended, press censored; JP = Lok Nayak; lifted 1977 → govt defeated
- **Case studies:** Jethipura (NDRGGSP 2019) • South Manubankul (women-friendly) • PESA 1996 & ADCs

14 🧠 Memory Tricks

🧠 **6 FRs "EFERCC":** Every Friend Enjoys Rasgulla, Cold Coffee — Equality, Freedom, Exploitation, Religion, Cultural, Constitutional remedies

🧠 **7 principles "PoReF SeAMS":** Popular sovereignty, Rule of law, FRs, Separation, Accountability, Multi-party, Safeguarding

🧠 **Emergency articles:** 352-National, 356-President's Rule, 360-Financial

🧠 **Accountability "C-C-L-C":** CAG, CIC, Lokpal, CVC

🧠 **FR articles:** "14 se Equality shuru, 32 par Court" — 14–18 → 19–22 → 23–24 → 25–28 → 29–30 → 32

🧠 **Women's vote "20-28-50":** USA-ne-1920, Britain-ne-1928, India-ne-1950

🧠 **Parliamentary vs Presidential:** "India mein PM Parliament se, USA mein President People se"

🧠 **Country types "S-D-P-P":** Switzerland-Direct, Presidential-USA, Parliamentary-India

15 ⚡ Last 5-Minute Revision — read before entering the exam hall

🗓️ DATES & NUMBERS

1946 CA; **26 Nov 1949** adopted; **26 Jan 1950** in force
2y 11m 18d drafting; **96.8 cr** voters; **140+ cr** people; **25 lakh** per MP
22 languages • 1 million+ stations • 2,800+ parties
RTI **2005** • PESA **1996** • RP Act **1951** • Art 21A **2009**
Women's vote: India **1950** / USA **1920** / Britain **1928** • Emergency **1975–77**

📜 ARTICLES

FRs: **14–18, 19–22, 23–24, 25–28, 29–30, 32** • 21A Education • 368 Amendment
46 SC/ST welfare • 243D Panchayat women ⅓ • 243T Municipality women ⅓ • 352/356/360 Emergency

👤 NAMES

Dr. B.R. Ambedkar — Chairman, Drafting Committee
Indira Gandhi — PM during Emergency • **Jayaprakash Narayan** (Lok Nayak) — resistance
Chaudhary Charan Singh, Babu Jagjivan Ram — grassroots leaders

🧠 7 PRINCIPLES (ONE BREATH)

Popular sovereignty → Rule of law → FRs → Separation of powers → Accountability & transparency → Multi-party → Safeguarding vulnerable (Art 46)

⚖️ KEY DIFFERENCES

Direct (Switzerland) vs Representative (India)
Parliamentary (executive IN legislature) vs Presidential (executive separate)
Equality before law vs equal protection of law
FRs (enforceable) vs Duties vs DPSP (guidelines) • India written vs UK unwritten constitution

⚡ RAPID-FIRE

sabhā/samiti/vidhata + gaṇa-saṁgha = democratic roots; Ṛig Veda **10.191.3**
Buddha's Saṁgha — debate, voting, elected leader
Media = fourth pillar • PIL = public interest court action • Quorum = minimum for valid meeting
Jethipura — NDRGGSP 2019 • Manubankul — women-friendly •
Emergency: June 1975 → lifted 1977, govt defeated
NSS + NCC + Scouts = civic responsibility programmes • ADCs & PESA = tribal self-governance

16 📝 How to Use These Points in an Answer

- **Formula:** Introduction (1–2 lines — define the concept) → Body (3–5 numbered points: keyword + article/example) → Conclusion (1 line judgement). Underline articles & dates.
- **Q: "What are the essential principles of democracy in India?" (5m):** Intro = thriving democracy rests on non-negotiable principles upheld by constitutional provisions. Body = ① popular sovereignty + UAF (18+, secret ballot) ② rule of law — no one above law ③ 6 FRs (Articles 14–32) ④ separation of powers — checks & balances, judicial review ⑤ accountability & transparency — RTI 2005, Question Hour + Article 46. Conclusion = power remains with the people, government stays accountable.
- **Q: "Is voting alone enough to make a country democratic? Justify." (5m):** Intro = voting is essential but democracy needs much more. Body = ① free & fair elections + independent ECI ② rule of law + FRs protected by judiciary ③ accountability — RTI, Question Hour, free press ④ participation beyond voting — Gram Sabhas, civil society, PIL ⑤ counter-example: Emergency 1975–77 — elections alone could not stop rights suspension; citizen vigilance needed. Conclusion = democracy is a continuous process needing informed citizens + strong institutions, not just ballot boxes.